

companies (Balco and Hindustan Zinc).

There were a lot of failures along the way, but it only made me stronger like Dara Singh. A lot of it is because of my courage and the support I got from many people.

Let's be clear about one thing. This will be a difficult journey for India, be it on oil and gas or bauxite or anything else. At the end of it, we are speaking of brick-and-mortar businesses. We lose foreign exchange in natural resources and that must change. We are confident that Vedanta is well-positioned to do all this.

Q: You have created scale in businesses over time. Is that one of your strengths even today?

A: We started manufacturing aluminium with a capacity of 1,00,00 tonnes per annum. Now we are at

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3 million tonnes, and the plan is to move to 6 million tonnes. Think about it. We have increased our capacity by 60 times and there is still a shortage! In zinc, we began with 2 million tonnes and hit 1.1 million tonnes. Now, we want to get to 2.2 million tonnes. Coming to silver, it was imported, but now we will be self-sufficient. Just look at the fertiliser opportunity in Rajasthan, where we have rock phosphate and sulphuric acid. We are looking to build India's largest fertiliser plant there.

Critical metals are super important. A lot of work is being done at HZL. Plus, we have taken mines for rare earth. We need support for all this. I am seated in a Ferrari at the start of the line waiting to take off. Our future is linked to natural resources. There are a few players today and we need a lot more.

A lot of people in the US and Canada have got into it. We cannot look at the industry with a negative mindset. It's not bad to make money.

I am confident India will become self-sufficient in the time to come.

Q: What has been the rationale for the demerger of Vedanta Ltd at this point?

A: Five is better than one (laughs). If you look at power, this is only the start, and I promise you the best is yet to come. In metals, we are the only producers of manganese and nickel. Vedanta owns mines in South Africa and that puts us in a position of great strength. Our steel business will have a meaningful role if India needs to get to a capacity of 300 million tonnes per annum.

Q: What do you have to say about Vedanta's low-cost model?

A: Yes, there is a strong focus in this area, and we are very good at it. A big reason for that is that we put technology to very good use and that means getting 25-30% more from the same asset. We think far ahead of competition. Our approach is a combination of technology and human interface. Technology alone is a black box.

Technology gives me higher multiples and tremendous scale. We want to be in businesses where there is double-digit growth, with the investor at the forefront. We see a lot of healthy competition among companies; all are in the growth phase.

Q: Tell us a little bit about how you go about choosing a new business.

A: Our focus is on natural resources and beyond that, technology, will help existing businesses. There is no diversion for us at this point. The space is very clear—and that is natural resources.

Q: What is the broad vision for Vedanta businesses in India?

A: The story has just started. In aluminium, we will make alloys and reduce costs by at least 20%. In mining, we will use technology and sit in the control room. In each business, costs will reduce and production will increase.

Natural resources are our play, and with critical metals, the size and scale of the opportunity have never been bigger. This a period of great transformation at Vedanta. Listing the companies throws open multiple options to raise money. To me, this is a new Vedanta.

Q: How concerned are you about the uncertain geopolitical environment and its impact on the global economy?